

CHAPTER 8

COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

OBJECTIVES

To write academic texts, you need to master certain skills.

In this chapter, you will learn to:

- Identify similarities and differences
- Organize comparison and contrast paragraphs
- Write supporting sentences to explain similarities and differences
- Use transition signals for comparison / contrast
- Write, revise, and edit a comparison / contrast paragraph about education in two different countries



INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 7, you learned about cause/effect paragraphs. Chapter 8 is about paragraphs that analyze similarities and differences. **Comparison / contrast** is a commonly used technique. For example, you compare and contrast courses and teachers when you decide which classes to take. You compare and contrast products and prices when you shop. In college classes, you will often have to compare and contrast. A professor in a political science class might ask you to write about the similarities and differences between two world leaders. In a literature class, you might have to compare two poems or two characters in a play. At the end of Chapter 8, you will write your own comparison / contrast paragraph.

TOPIC SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

The topic sentence of a comparison / contrast paragraph should name the topic (the two subjects that you are comparing or contrasting) and indicate the controlling idea (whether the focus of the paragraph is on similarities, differences, or both).

To understand 21st century education, let's examine the similarities and differences between the schools of 50 years ago and the schools of today.

When students are applying to colleges, they should consider differences in class size, academic standards, and tuition.

The Olympics of ancient Greece and the Olympics of today have three key differences.

SUPPORTING SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

In block organization, you group all the similarities together in one block and all of the differences together in one block. Look at this outline for the writing model on pages 172–173 if the writer had used block organization. Notice how the supporting details are presented.

CONCLUDING SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

The conclusion of a comparison / contrast paragraph may repeat the topic sentence or restate similarities and differences. It may also give an opinion or a recommendation.

In conclusion, after students weigh the differences in quality and cost, they may decide to choose a smaller, less expensive college that nevertheless has high academic standards.

To sum up, the ancient Olympics and the modern Olympics differ in their purpose, participants, and events.

FOCUS ON SIMILARITIES AND DIFFERENCES PARAGRAPH

PARAGRAPH 2

Choosing an Eye Care Professional

_____ Optometrists and ophthalmologists offer many of the same services. Like optometrists, ophthalmologists give eye exams to find out if their patients have 20/20 vision. If not, the two kinds of eye doctors prescribe glasses or contact lenses to correct the problem. In addition, both optometrists and ophthalmologists diagnose and treat injuries and common diseases of the eye. However, there are differences between optometrists and ophthalmologists that are related to their education and training. Optometrists usually receive a Doctor of Optometry (O.D.) degree after four years of study at the undergraduate level and four years of graduate school. In contrast, ophthalmologists complete four years of undergraduate study, four years of medical school, and a one-year internship before they receive the Doctor of Medicine (M.D.) degree. They then finish at least three years of residency training. Because they are medical doctors, ophthalmologists can prescribe more kinds of medicine and do more in-depth treatment than optometrists. Most importantly, optometrists cannot perform surgery, but ophthalmologists can. In short, both optometrists and ophthalmologists can provide the eye care that most people need. However, only ophthalmologists have the training to treat certain eye problems, especially problems that require surgery.



- a. Both optometrists and ophthalmologists are qualified eye doctors, but they are not the same.
- b. Optometrists cannot perform eye surgery, but ophthalmologists can.
- c. Optometrists and ophthalmologists are two very different kinds of eye doctors.
- d. It is very difficult to see the difference between optometrists and ophthalmologists.

TRANSITION SIGNALS FOR COMPARISON

In Chapter 4 and again in Chapter 7, you learned how to use transition signals to write coherent paragraphs with sentences that are well-connected and flow smoothly. Review the rules and explanations for transition signals on pages 161–163.

This chart shows some transition signals that you can use to express similarity. It is followed by rules, explanations, and examples that add to what you learned in Chapter 4 and Chapter 7.

SIGNALS TO SHOW SIMILARITIES				
Sentence Connectors	Coordinating Conjunctions	Paired Conjunctions	Subordinating Conjunctions	Others
similarly likewise also too	and . . . (too)	both . . . and not only . . . but also	as just as	similar equal the same similar to equal to (just) like the same as equally

In addition, . . .
Similarly, . . .
Likewise, . . .

San Francisco has a mild climate with wet winters and dry summers. **Similarly**, Sydney's winters are quite mild.

EQUALITY

as + adjective / adverb + as
the same + noun + as

The weather in Moscow is **as extreme as** Chicago's.
Cricket has **the same number of** players **as** soccer.

Sentence Connectors

Also often appears in the middle or at the end of a sentence. Don't use *also* with a semicolon.

British English reverses the order of subjects and verbs in questions.
American English **also** changes word order for questions.

British English reverses the order of subjects and verbs in questions.
American English changes word order for questions **also**.

Too usually comes at the end of a sentence. It often appears together with the coordinating conjunction *and*. Some writers put a comma before *too* at the end of a sentence, but it is not required.

British English uses *do* and *did* for negative statements in the simple present and the simple past; American English uses these auxiliary verbs, **too**.

British English uses *do* and *did* for negative statements in the simple present and the simple past, and American English uses these auxiliary verbs **too**.

Paired Conjunctions

Paired conjunctions are always used together. Notice that the word that comes after the second conjunction must be the same part of speech (noun, verb, adverb, and so on) as the word that comes after the first conjunction. This is called **parallelism**.

The vocabulary of British and American English is **both** colorful **and** large.

The vocabulary of British and American English is **not only** colorful **but also** large.

CORRECT The vocabulary of British and American English is both

ADJECTIVE ADJECTIVE
colorful and large.

INCORRECT The vocabulary of British and American English is both

ADJECTIVE VERB PHRASE
colorful and has thousands of words.

NOUN NOUN
Both **prefixes** and **suffixes** are important in the vocabulary of British and American English.

Native speakers of British and American English not only **understand**
but also **use** prefixes such as *bi-*, *trans-*, and *sub-* in new words.

With prefixes, native speakers can create new words that are both

ADJECTIVE ADJECTIVE
logical and functional.

In British and American English, words with the suffixes *-or/er*, *-ness*, and

-ment are used both **formally** and **informally**.

The same suffixes appear both **in British English** and **in American English**.

Subordinating Conjunctions

As is a subordinating word. It begins a dependent clause. The word *just* makes it stronger. Notice that you use a comma even when the independent clause comes first. This is an exception to the usual rule.

American English requires subject-verb agreement, **as / just as** British English does.

Others

Similar, *equal*, and *the same* act like adjectives; that is, they describe nouns.

British English and American English sentences have **similar** patterns.

Similar to, *equal to*, *(just) like*, and *the same as* act like prepositions. They come in front of nouns, noun phrases, and pronouns to make prepositional phrases.

Hundreds of British English grammar rules are **the same as** the rules of American English.

Like British English, American English has formal grammar rules for academic writing.

Equally is an adverb. It describes an adjective (*complex*) in the following example. An adverb can also describe a verb or another adverb.

British English and American English are **equally** complex.

PRACTICE 6**Using Parallelism with Comparison Signals**

Complete the sentences. Use the words and phrases from the box. Follow the rules of parallelism. Use each word or phrase once.

difficult	for academic English
effectively	in British English
end with special punctuation	negatives

1. Question marks are used both in British English and in American English.
2. In English, not only questions but also _____ have the auxiliary verbs *do* and *did*.
3. In British English and American English, questions not only _____ but also change subject-verb word order.
4. English grammar is both interesting and _____.
5. Prefixes are useful not only for everyday English but also _____.
6. Skilled writers use words creatively and _____.

PRACTICE 7**Combining Ideas with Comparison Signals**

Combine the ideas in each pair of sentences to make one or two sentences. Use the comparison signal in parentheses. Capitalize and punctuate the sentences correctly. Reword the sentences as needed.

1. The Internet has helped make English a world language. (like)
Global businesses have helped make English a world language.

Like the Internet, global businesses have helped to make English a world language.

2. English language movies appear in theaters worldwide. (too)
English is commonly used on the Internet.

3. British English has become an international language. (similarly)
American English is now heard in locations around the globe.

4. English is the language spoken in Britain and the United States. **(just as)**
English is the language spoken in Canada, Australia, and New Zealand.

5. More than 350 million people speak English as their first language. **(likewise)**
Millions of people speak English as an additional language.

PRACTICE 8

Writing Sentences with Comparison Signals

Write sentences of comparison. Use the information and comparison signal in parentheses, and add a verb.

1. The Spanish language / the Italian language **(similar to)**

The Spanish language is similar to the Italian language.

2. Knowing a second language / useful for / travel / employment **(not only ... but also)**

3. Latin / the Greek language / the origin of many English words **(like)**

4. Loan words such as *mosquito*, *patio*, and *plaza* / spelling / in English and Spanish **(the same)**

5. Word knowledge/cultural experience/a role in language learning **(both ... and)**

DISTANCE, FREQUENCY, AND MANNER CLAUSES

Adverb clauses of distance answer the question "How far?" Adverb clauses of frequency answer the question "How often?" Adverb clauses of manner answer the question "How?" Distance, frequency, and most (but not all) manner clauses follow the independent clause.

DISTANCE, FREQUENCY, AND MANNER SUBORDINATORS	EXAMPLES
as + (adverb) + as: distance	Fire had destroyed the trees in the forest as far as the eye could see .
as + (adverb) + as: frequency	I do not visit my parents as often as they would like me to .
as: manner	We mixed the chemicals exactly as the lab instructor had told us to .
as + (adverb) + as: manner	Our instructor asked us to fill out the questionnaire as carefully as we could .
as if, as though: manner	The bus's engine sounds as if / as though it is going to stall at any moment.

Notes

- In informal spoken English, people often use *like* in place of *as if* and *as though*. *Like* is not correct in formal written English, so use only *as if* and *as though* in your writing.

FORMAL It looks **as if** it is going to rain.

INFORMAL It looks **like** it is going to rain.

- In very formal written English, the verb takes the same form as it does in conditional clauses when the information in the *as if* / *as though* clause is untrue (or probably untrue). However, many English speakers use normal verb forms in this situation.

FORMAL John acts as if he **were** the Prince of Wales.

INFORMAL John acts as if he **is** the Prince of Wales.

PRACTICE 3

Using Distance, Frequency, and Manner Clauses

- A** Complete the sentences by adding a distance, frequency, or manner clause. Use your own ideas. Use each subordinator at least once.

1. People should try to recycle as often as they can. (frequency)
2. Most people want to move _____. (distance)
3. We should not consume our natural resources _____. (manner)
4. Should teenagers have the right to dress _____? (manner)
5. No nation in the world can afford to act _____. (manner—use *as if* or *as though*)

- B** Answer the questions with sentences containing a clause of distance, frequency, or manner. Make sure that your answer contains two complete clauses: an independent clause and an adverb clause. (Hint: A phrase such as *as fast as possible* is not a clause.)

1. How does your writing instructor want you to write your essays?

Our writing instructor wants us to write our essays as thoughtfully as we can.

2. How should you act when you see an enraged elephant running toward you?

3. How can you overcome stage fright¹? (Use *as if* or *as though* in your sentence.)

4. How can you perfect your pronunciation of a foreign language?

5. When the teacher catches you sleeping in class, how can you avoid embarrassment? (Use *as if* or *as though* in your sentence.)

WRITING PRACTICE

Write a paragraph to compare and contrast the *knowledge gained from experiences vs the knowledge gained from books*

There are both similarities and differences between [A] and [B], and each has its own advantages and disadvantages. **This paragraph will first discuss the similarities between the two before moving on to their main differences.**

To begin with, [A] and [B] are similar in several ways. One important similarity is that they both In addition, not only [A] but also [B], which means that

However, despite these similarities, there are also some clear differences between the two.

To begin with, [A] is generally different from [B] in [aspect 1]. [A], whereas [B] tends to be As a result, Another noticeable difference can be seen in [aspect 2]. While [A], [B] This shows that

In conclusion, although both [A] and [B] share some similarities, I believe that [A / B] is the better choice because